Dressing

By Mona Mansour and Tala Manassah

SON: Part one: He's off to school. His pants hang low – This is an issue.

MOM: *(grabbing a belt loop on her son's pants, which are hanging low. They engage in a conversation, having fun. They like this ritual)* This is an issue. Do you know where it came from? This style, this – symbol. It's a symbol of . . .

SON: *(Wresting away and readjusting his pants to the lower level)* I know. Prison. Prisoners aren't allowed to have belts. See? I remember.

MOM: Right. And the pants sag. Which even just symbolically plays into

SON: School-to-prison pipeline, all that . . . *(Smiles)* But I have 3.8. [GPA] *(Mom smiles. He pulls his pants back up to appease her)* Okay? *(laughing)* Just leave it, please?

MOM: I just worry . . . It feels symbolic to me. A competition over who has the best armor. *(he pulls on a t-shirt)* And what is this? I don't understand why you can't wear the ones I got you.

SON: The button-up-the-front things? Yeah. Not today. *(She gives him a look)* Another day . . .

MOM: Um-hmm, when's that?

SON: When I turn into a Jehovah's Witness and go door to door selling Bibles. *(He laughs and exits)*

INTRODUCTION

For years now, many of us have supported the movement to "pull up your pants" but have not looked at how the judgment and condemnation of Black youth, be it hoodies or sagging pants, is directly linked to racist stereotypes.

In fact, after the Tayvon Martin shooting in 2012; a message was sent by the media warning parents not to let their children wear hoodies. Why? Because it sends a sinister signal. You see, 17-year-old Tayvon Martin was wearing a "dark hoodie," which led a George Zimmerman to conclude that he was a "suspicious guy" and ultimately led to Martin's shooting death.

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Hardworking or lazy; trustworthy or dangerous: People too often make assumptions about someone's character and personality based solely on how they're dressed. What we must realize is a tailored suit does not mean innocence, nor do sagging pants or a hoodie mean guilt. Dress is not a reason for someone to be to be condemned nor it is a reason for someone to be harmed.

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MOM: Part two. No. Not part two. Not yet. I can't. I'm gonna – Just talk for a minute. About other things . . . I used to take him to tae kwon do – I'd stand with all the other parents in the window, watching, these wiggly little bodies punching, you know, they look ridiculous. And it's the same routine every time. But you stand there. These parents who say EVERYTHING THEIR CHILD DOES IS MAGICAL? They are lying. And I mean, I coulda done other things with my time. We both could have. But you want to create a foundation.

Give him that mental-physical discipline.

So once when he was like eight or so, I left to take a call, I'm gone fifteen minutes, maybe?, I come back, and suddenly he's doing these kicks, these crazy double kicks. He's two feet off the ground. Suddenly everything's coordinated. He's like a little pro. Now how did that happen? Two years of these lessons and nothing seems to click.

And I think: Was I watching him too hard?

Did my leaving help him to make that leap? Did he need me to stop watching just so he could stretch that way?

You have to be able to look away, to turn around, to let go. But how? *(and she doesn't want to, but she says . . .)*

Part Two. The mother gets a phone call. *(We hear 3 loud pops . . . a long beat)*

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You have to so gee – Someone drives you. And as they drive, you remember the pain of childbirth, the tenuousness of those first moments, you remember small eyes, and small gasps, and the very tiny hands that reached for you. Tiny hands reaching.

You don't remember how you got here. To this building. But somehow you know exactly where to go.

Cause we've been doing this dance, right? We know how to do this! We know where to go, we know how to behave! **And** they take you into this room, and then another one, and another one, and your legs move, something primordial moves you forward, and you dig your nails into your hands so you won't feel anything, and it's not YOUR body that moves you forward. It's – that body, the one that's in your core.

THIS is the thing that you have been carrying. Always carrying.

It's all going forward now, you don't want it to be, it's going forward, time, and your body, you have no choice. And finally: There it is . . . And there it is . . . And there it is. *(Long beat)*

Part Three: She folds his clothes. *(She's back at home. In his room, or at least with his clothes. She's folding them)*

I used to go into his closet and move these three thirst – button up the front ones – I'd put, put them in the front, like he would suddenly see them and realize he wanted to wear them. Like moving the okra on his plate so he'd want to eat it – "See how good this looks?" Ridiculous.

It's not about class. It was never about that. Me trying to get him dressed up so we could elevate him in other people's eyes. Not really.

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The clothes . . . It's . . . you do these thing, these small things to protect his . . . protect his . . . . his *(She breaks)* body. That body. Oh. *(She buries her face in the clothes)* Oh, vulnerable body. I thought I knew. How much. Oh.

I heard someone on – you know, some panel, say this thing: Men in black bodies have since the founding of this country been vulnerable by way of the body that they inhabit. Oh. That's a crazy thing to think about, that's a crazy thing to carry. For him. Right.

(She holds one of the shirts) And this – these – never were going to protect him. Were they? Why did I think they could? *(Clarity. Beyond pain. Exhaustion. Beat)*

And now I will do another dance.

With other mothers, some that I know on a molecular level, and some who live in places I don't even know exist. I would like to know those women, but not in this way. This is an involuntary and wicked dance. *(She is alone with the shirt, maybe hums a song)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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